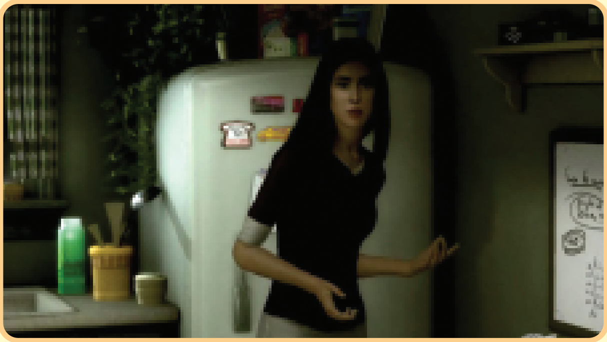
Myth: You need the latest to run the latest.

If you could peel yourself away from the online forums for a while and stop breathing in the hyperbole, "LOL YOU NEEDZ $5000 PC TO RUNZ CRYSIS!!! CONSOLES FTW!" you would come to the realisation that game developers are smart enough to cater to an audience that does not have the latest hardware. Games do run on low-end machines. Yes, you might need to lower settings to get to a decent frame rate but having a low-specced computer does not make you a gaming pariah. The trick with PC gaming is to catch the tech / cost curve at just the right moment. Since hardware refreshes are almost an annual ritual, with major changes every two years, you just need to be a little patient before jumping in headlong and picking up a $500 graphic card and a $300 processor. A smarter approach is to invest in previous generation hardware, after the latest has been unleashed. This generally implies going for something cheaper (sometimes half as cheap!), which performs almost as well as the latest. Currently, for example—the 8800GT graphics card is a great pick, and so is say, the E7200 processor from Intel. But just wait a bit longer, when NVIDIA and AMD release their next batch come June, and you can enjoy even lower prices on the graphics card.

So, how about the $5000 PC to run the best games myth? *Crysis* runs just fine on a "$600 machine"; let's flesh it out a bit. $150 for an Intel Core 2 Duo E7200 processor + $180 for an XFX GeForce 8800GT + about a $100 for a Gigabyte Motherboard that supports the two, add some RAM and you get a pretty good build for about $600. The reason for being so specific about the hardware necessary to run *Crysis*, is to clear away the myth that you need to invest a lot of money to play PC games. Another point to note here is that *Crysis* is the best-of-breed—no game, not even an HD console game—can touch its visual fidelity so far. This implies that if your PC can run *Crysis* at even a decent frame rate, it can blaze through the hundreds of other titles on the computer that are available out there.

Alan Wake
Realistic cloud formations and skies, day / night time cycles, ambient occlusion, and more! *Alan Wake* promises a visual feast upon release



Heavy Rain
You looking at me? 'Heavy Rain' has been showcased showing a 'realistic' character who cries but manages to freak one out thanks to the Uncanny Valley.

Heavy Rain
Look at me! The same game a few months later shows a much improved character and a much reduced impact of the Valley

Myth: The HD Console Games Look Great And The PC Will Never Catch Up

This is such a ridiculous position to take. In fact, even to address it lends some credence to idiocy. Fact: The greatest games on these consoles do not even run at HD resolutions. *Halo 3* runs at 640p, and not 720p. Besides, it's upscaled. *Call of Duty 4* runs at 600p, not 720p and is upscaled. *Haze* runs at 576p, not 720p and is upscaled. The point here is not to belittle these great titles—the resolution does not matter, these are fun, great games. The point is that the consoles are not powerful enough to run games at the resolutions that their manufacturers shouted from the rooftops. The amount of bandwidth offered and the amount of memory available to the graphic chips of these consoles is simply not enough to create games, which are impossible to make on the personal computer. The reality is that a developer on the PC can create games that will not be possible on the consoles until next-generation ones arrive. The reason being the graphic chips that power these consoles—they are "last-gen", at best. Just to drive in this reality, consider *Lost Planet: Extreme Conditions*. This game was released in January 2007 for the Xbox 360, running at 720p and hailed as a great-looking shooter. The same game made its PC debut in June sporting even better graphics, with full-screen anti-aliasing and